

Foucault's Apparatus of Power and Game Interactivity: A Case Study of "Please, Do Not Touch Anything"

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1. Introduction

In contemporary society, games have been established as a distinctive form of media which extends beyond mere entertainment or consumer goods. "Interactivity, however problematic, is intrinsic to the computer gameplay experience, and thus, central to an understanding of computer games." [1] Based on this core feature of games, players directly participate and experience immersion, which distinguishes games from other media. This distinctive characteristic is also evident in the three-stage model of immersion—engagement, engrossment, and total immersion—proposed by Brown and Cairns through grounded theory [2].

Since the late 1990s, with the advancement of computer technology, the game industry has grown rapidly, and academic research on games has emerged accordingly [3]. Scholars such as Grant Tavinor and Noel Carroll have argued that games should be understood not merely as entertainment but as a form of popular art [3]. This perspective broadened the discussion of games, bringing them into the realms of aesthetics and philosophy.

In this context, this paper interprets games not simply as leisure activities but as a medium that can be understood within a philosophical and aesthetic framework. Focusing on the act of "not pressing the button" in the game *Please, Don't Touch Anything*, this study applies Michel Foucault's concepts of power and apparatus (*dispositif*) to analyze how control and regulation are operated within gameplay behavior. Through this approach, the study seeks to reconsider games from a philosophical-aesthetic perspective and to reinterpret them within Foucault's theoretical framework.

2. Theoretical Background

2.1 Foucault's Concept of Power and Apparatus

Foucault argued that knowledge cannot be separated from power relations. As he writes, "Knowledge and power are integrated with one another, and there is no point in dreaming of a time when knowledge will cease to depend on power; ... it is impossible for knowledge not to engender power" [4]. According to him, one of the primary ways in which power operates within society and discourse is through normalization [5].

Power and knowledge are inseparable: each presupposes, defines, and constitutes the other [5]. In this sense, Foucault's notion of apparatus (*dispositif*) refers to the network of discursive and non-discursive elements—institutions, laws, norms, and practices—that organize and regulate human behavior.

2.2 Foucault's "Dislocated Calligram"

A calligram is a poem whose text visually forms a shape representing its subject [6]. While calligrams traditionally unify language and image—where words signify objects and objects reflect words—René Magritte's *The Treachery of Images* (1929), which depicts a pipe with the caption "Ceci n'est pas une pipe" ("This is not a pipe"), subverts this relationship. The sentence beneath the image causes a disjunction between image and text, revealing that the picture does not represent a pipe. This work of art implies that an image cannot directly represent its subject. Foucault refers to this as the "unraveled calligram", asserting that the essence of painting is not representation, but the exploration of the relation (and rupture) between the visible and the sayable [7].

2.3 Formal Elements of Games

Fullerton et al. [8] divided the components of games into formal and dramatic elements. According to them, the formal elements include *Players*, *Objectives*, *Procedures*, *Rules*, *Resources*, *Conflict*, *Boundaries*, and *Outcomes*. Among these, *Objectives* can be further categorized into eight types. One of these, the "Forbidden Act", refers to objectives that require players to maintain a specific state or refrain from a particular action.

For example, in *"Jenga"* (1983, Leslie Scott; later marketed by Hasbro), the goal is to remove wooden blocks without collapsing the tower. In *"Twister"* (1966, Milton Bradley Company), players must keep their hands and feet on specific-colored circles. A player who loses balance or touches a circle of an incorrect color is considered defeated. In such games, the prohibition of certain acts becomes the objective of games.

3. Case Analysis: "Please, Don't Touch Anything"

3.1 Game Overview

"Please, Don't Touch Anything" (2015) is a puzzle game developed by the indie studio Four Quarters. At the beginning of the game, the player receives a request by another character to "watch the panel for a moment" and is strictly told not to touch anything. No further instructions are provided; the only visible element is a single, conspicuous red button designed to draw the player's attention.

Interestingly, beneath this explicit prohibition lies a more complex instruction: to press the button in specific sequences or patterns. For instance, pressing the button eight times reveals a screwdriver, which is used to open a

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panel and trigger the Yin-Yang Ending. Pressing it twenty times produces a Shutdown Ending, cutting off power to the room. Ultimately, the goal of game is not to avoid pressing the button entirely, but rather to discover the proper ways of pressing it in order to unlock hidden outcomes.

3.2 The Button and the Prohibited Act

Several games take the act of prohibition itself as their central objective, making the avoidance of pressing a button the very goal of play. People rarely question the seemingly self-evident proposition that “a button is meant to be pressed,” for in everyday life we encounter countless buttons.

However, Foucault is a philosopher who problematizes this sense of naturalness. From his perspective, a button is not a mere object; it is produced within the operations of power, and its functionality is constituted through technological practices and discourses. Foucault argued that modern technologies and apparatuses—such as schools, barracks, hospitals, and prisons—function as sites where disciplinary power organizes and regulates human behavior [4]. In the same sense, a button can be understood as an apparatus that induces a particular form of action. It is not simply a mechanical component but a kind of social sign that compels the act of pressing.

For instance, when we enter a café, we have no choice but to press the door-opening button. There is no other socially acceptable way to enter: staring at an employee or knocking on the door would be considered “abnormal.” The same applies to kiosks. The existence of these digitally excluded groups reveals how those who cannot press a button are regarded as “abnormal” within our technologically mediated society.

This tendency reflects Foucault’s idea that technologies and apparatuses guide and constrain human behavior, shaping “the general behavioral options that persons within the system obey, often ... according to societal norms” [5]. Even when instructed not to press the button, players do so because social norms have internalized the belief that pressing a button is the “normal” action.

Foucault argues that power is “not simply repressive, negative, or interdictive, but positive in the sense of constituting reality.” [9] In this sense, power does not merely limit or forbid action; it organizes action, produces knowledge, and disciplines the body. Similarly, “*Please, Don’t Touch Anything*” does not simply prohibit pressing the button; it seduces the player to act and then regulates how that action unfolds. The player is granted freedom, yet only structured freedom—one that yields results only when exercised within prescribed rules. This aligns with Foucault’s notion that modern disciplinary societies allow freedom, but always within a structured and normalized system.

3.3 The Button and the Calligram

Furthermore, the red button exemplifies Foucault’s “unraveled calligram.” [7] Like Magritte’s *The Treachery of Images*, where the text “This is not a pipe” contradicts the image of a pipe [7], the game’s verbal command “Do not touch” conflicts with its visual appeal. The glowing red button seems to beg the player to press it, creating a tension between instruction and desire. Thus, the game becomes a site where linguistic prohibition and visual invitation collide, reflecting Foucault’s insight into the rupture between image and language, in which “image and text fall each to its own side” and “no longer do they have a common ground” [7].

4. Conclusion

The mechanisms of power and discipline described by Foucault—normalization, regulation, and structured freedom—are deeply embedded within the systems and rules that govern gameplay. *Please, Don’t Touch Anything* exemplifies this dynamic: while ostensibly prohibiting an action, it simultaneously provokes and regulates actions, embodying the operation of power as described by Foucault. Through such examples, games become a medium through which philosophical inquiry can occur—inviting players to question assumptions, challenge perceptual norms, and reflect on the relationship between freedom, control, and desire.

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